

# Avoiding the climate “ambition trap”

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**A**t the United Nations General Assembly in September, President Xi of China delivered a noteworthy update in what has been a dismal year for climate news: China would reduce its greenhouse gas emissions by 7 to 10% from its peak levels by 2035. For many, this was welcome news. But others deemed China’s pledge insufficiently “ambitious.” Yet the conceptual and political basis for climate ambition is unclear. This matters in a year when countries will submit updated emissions pledges under the Paris Agreement.

Climate ambition, or seriousness of intent to address climate change, is often measured by benchmarking national pledges against global temperature targets. The goal is to identify and hail first-movers to generate a virtuous cascade of emissions pledges. According to analysts, a truly ambitious Chinese pledge would have aimed at 20 to 30% reductions to be compatible with the Paris Agreement’s 2°C temperature goal and 1.5°C aspiration. By this benchmark, China’s pledge was considered disappointing. Yet, most commentators also noted that Beijing’s style is to underpromise and overdeliver and that China will likely “overcomply” with their pledge. Policies already in place will likely get China to at least 10% reductions; expected policies to come will yield deeper, if uncertain, cuts.

Analysts seemed to give more weight to what China said than to a reasoned judgment of what the country would actually do. Their disappointment stemmed from China’s reluctance to use its pledge as a beacon attracting action by others. But assessing ambition based on what a country says, rather than what it does or is likely to do, is a problem for at least three reasons.

One reason is that assessing ambition is laden with normative judgment, rendering comparison suspect. To judge a single country’s pledge against global temperature targets requires assessing that country’s share of global responsibility. Yet operationalizing distributional questions of climate equity has proved politically intractable given different capabilities and historical emissions. A workaround has been to benchmark against least-cost pathways, but this ignores equity. Or to devise allocation ranges across equity principles, but this results in broad ranges that undercut comparability. Both approaches undermine the moral weight intended to drive virtuous pledge cascades.

Another reason is that there is little evidence of a clear link between ambition of pledges and what countries actually do. There may even be an “ambition trap”: Without accountability mechanisms, countries have an incentive to reap quick reputational rewards of unrealistically high pledges. Cross-country analysis suggests some evidence for an inverse

relationship between ambition and the likelihood of implementation. Pledges that outstrip domestic capability to act may be counterproductive because they erode the credibility of the Paris pledge process.

In addition, changes in domestic politics have historically been a more effective driver of action than pressures for global cooperation. Drivers will differ with national context. Climate-adjacent concerns such as air pollution or green jobs may motivate action more than existential climate politics. In other words, emissions may be the caboose, not the engine, of the climate train.

None of this is to suggest that the pledge-making process is not useful. The spotlight of regular international attention and associated reputational risk serves to mobilize and incentivize bureaucracies, create space for civil society voices, and spur attention to policy frameworks. But it is to say that attention should shift to supporting domestic dynamics rather than naming and shaming.

Nor is it to suggest that country pledges should be taken at face value. That China has committed to being on an emissions downslope is good news, but the failure to specify an emissions peak year leaves room for expanded coal use. If China is to underpromise but overcomply, evidence of new and stronger policies is essential. China’s dominance in green technology is important, but will its interests be best served by accelerating low-carbon development elsewhere or by guarding its dominance? As the United States opts out of the low-carbon race, this concern is particularly salient.

A global shift in emphasis is needed, from benchmarking pledges to understanding what they signal about how and why countries will act. Questions include whether pledges stack up against current national policies, rather than abstract global emissions futures; whether sectoral plans exist that are sufficiently detailed to attract financing and are embedded in legal, institutional, and regulatory frameworks to enable implementation; and whether policies reinforce politically popular issues that are climate-adjacent. Global temperature targets are important, but they serve better as a guide against which to judge actual progress *ex post* than speculative intent *ex ante*.

Paris-derived country pledges are worthy of attention and scrutiny. But benchmarking a country against itself may be more productive than devising speculative global benchmarks in the hope of talking-up pledges. Instead of emissions beacons, there should be evidence of a political and economic turn toward a low-carbon future. □

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10.1126/science.aed3356